Where Slang is Born and Where It Goes to Die

A data analysis of how approval, emphasis, and insulting terms reveal the unwritten rules of social media

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Every platform has its own language; spend enough time on TikTok and you'll hear terms like "slay" and "bussin" everywhere, wander into a Twitch stream, and "mid" is the default verdict for anything underwhelming while on Reddit, "based" reads like the highest compliment a stranger can pay you.

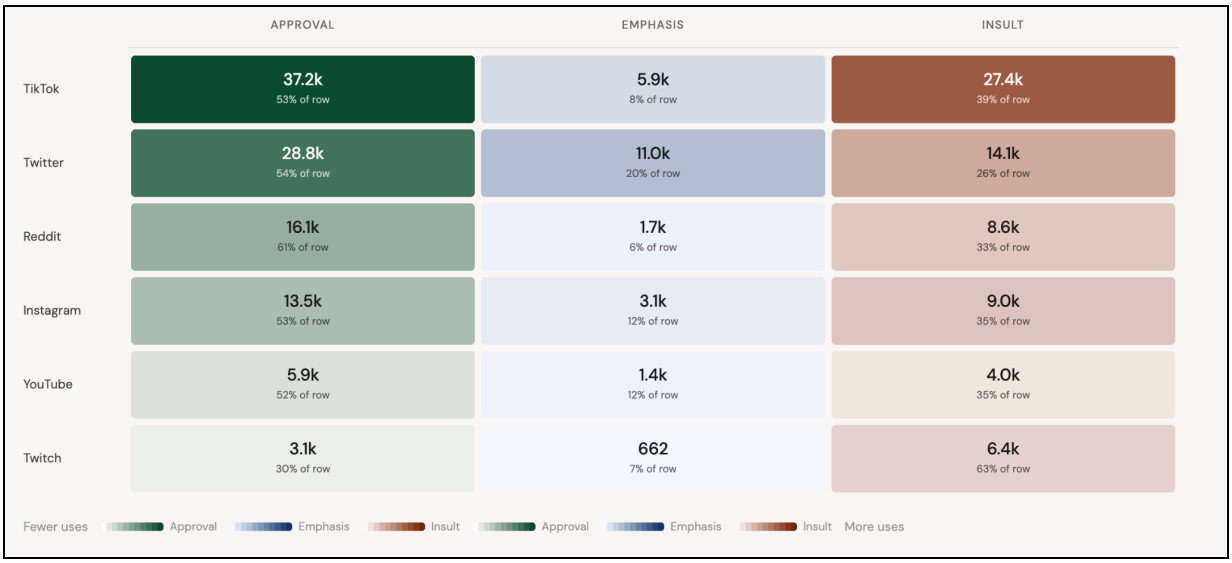
This is not a coincidence. The data shows it is a pattern, and the pattern says something about how each platform is built, who uses it, and what it rewards.

An analysis of more than 200,000 documented uses of slang terms across six major platforms—TikTok, Twitter, Instagram, Reddit, YouTube, and Twitch— reveals that the slang we reach for online isn't random. It clusters by function, platform structure, and user comfortability.

When you break down slang by intent—approval, emphasis, and insult— the data reflects something that is both social and strategic.

Approval terms dominate the dataset by a wide margin, terms like "slay", "bussin", "based", "ate", "valid", and "understood the assignment" account for more than 100,00 out of 200,00 uses examined; nearly double the volume of insult terms and more than four times that of emphasis terms. Additionally, those terms also earn the most social engagement across platforms. On platforms built around visual performance and public validation, these terms function as a social currency.

TikTok and Twitter are highly-concentrated platforms for slang usage and creation. TikTok alone accounts for more than 37,000 uses of approval-category slang. TikTok is a platform where content is consumed rapidly, comment sections scroll fast, and a well-placed "slay" doubles as both a thumbs-up and a declaration of cultural fluency.



Alexandra Johnston, a sociolinguist at Georgetown University focuses on intercultural communication, describes this as something more structural than casual.

“Some of the ways we interact with people transfer to online, and sometimes the online-only forms of communication translate offline and affect how we behave offline, “ Johnston said.

The comment box did not invent the need to signal approval, it just made the signal faster and louder. The data also slows that approval terms travel the furthest. “Slay” is the single most-used term on TikTok, “Ate” leads Twitter, and “Based” dominates Reddit, where it originated in male-coded forum culture before migrating outward.

This kind of migration—born in one community, adopted by another—is the normal life cycle of digital language.

Minnie Quartey, an adjunct lecturer in Georgetown’s linguistics department who studies African American language and recently consulted with NBC on a feature about Gen-Z slang, put it differently.

“Before there was online, before the online space was really prevalent, maybe 10, 15, 20 years ago, regionality was so much more prevalent,” Quartey said.

Slang that belonged to a neighborhood, city or subculture had a natural boundary.

“Now with online, and information being exchanged so quickly and linguistic contact happening so frequently, you see a lot more of this infusion and blending,” Quartey said.

The leveling effect of social media doesn’t erase origins, it accelerates them past their source communities before those communities can claim credit.

Terms like “delulu”, “NPC”, “mid”, “touch grass”, “simp” and “cheugy” account for more than 70,000 uses and generate some of the highest average vitality scores. This makes sense if you understand what insults are for online.

They don’t just offend, they sort. “Mid” on Twitch is a gatekeeping term: it defines what belongs inside a community’s standards versus what falls soft. “Simp” on Reddit’s usage figures, emerged from longer-form community critique and still carries that weight. Similarly, the phrase, “touch grass” is “get off the Internet” in one phrase and serves as one of Twitter’s sharpest insults.

Quartey described the dynamic plainly; linguistic appropriation occurs in certain spaces on the Internet.

“Everybody wants to be Black until they have to be Black. We want to appreciate all the things that’s cool of Black culture, but we don’t want to experience all the heartache and all the trauma,” Quartey said.

Linguistic appropriation is colloquially talking about how slang terms exist in their original communities with their meaning partially intact and yet their history is largely stripped away.

“We take what we like, and we leave the stuff that’s not as palatable. We relabel it,” Johnston said.

The term, “woke,” is a great example of this phenomenon: originating and circulated in African-American communities to describe awareness of institutionalized racism, was “recirculated” into political discourse by figures who mean to demean liberal, political ideologies or display overly-sensitive behaviors to social issues.

The point is not just historical grievance, but the data reflects it structurally. The insult category is the most platform-specific of the three: “mid” belongs to Twitch, “NPC” and “delulu” belongs to TikTok, and “simp” belongs to Reddit. These terms are doing precise social work inside digital communities that have their own norms, gatekeepers, definitions of in-group and out-groups.

Across all three intent categories, usage peaks at the 18-24 age group and drops with each cohort, but the slope is gradual enough that even the 41+ group registers significantly in each category especially in the approval and insult terms.

Age × Platform | **Age × Intent** | Platform × Intent

	APPROVAL	EMPHASIS	INSULT
13–17	26.6k 53% of row	6.1k 12% of row	17.7k 35% of row
18–24	37.3k 53% of row	8.4k 12% of row	24.8k 35% of row
25–30	21.6k 53% of row	4.8k 12% of row	14.3k 35% of row
31–40	12.9k 53% of row	2.9k 12% of row	8.6k 35% of row
41+	8.5k 53% of row	1.9k 12% of row	5.7k 35% of row

This means that slang isn't purely adolescent vocabularies. Johnston cautioned against generational ownership of slang as a fixed phenomenon.

"There are other things that stick with people over time and actually change the language," Johnston said, "Words change their meanings all the time, depending on who uses them and how much power the group who uses those words has."

Johnston traced how the "Valley Girl" speech patterns from the 1970s San Fernando Valley (rising intonation and the quotative usage of "like") eventually spread nationally and persisted into adulthood for many speakers. Today's "slay" is not guaranteed to disappear when its current users turn 30.

The 13-17 group shows particularly high engagement with insult terms, second only to the 18-24 group, which likely reflects the dominance of gaming culture and meme communities in younger users' social media use.

Ultimately, digital-linguistic study is about more than just words; it is about perspective. The way we choose to approve or insult someone online reflects our growing reliance on digital means to satisfy basic

human social needs. When we analyze a heatmap of slang, we aren't just looking at trends; we are looking at a map of human connection in the 21st century.

As we continue to evolve alongside the internet, understanding these informal languages becomes crucial. Slang is the "source code" of our digital interactions. By critically reviewing and visualizing it, we can better understand the evolution of our society as we move further into a tech-integrated future.

LIMITATIONS

The dataset analyzed here is synthetic and is modeled on real-world slang patterns, but not drawn from live platform data. It can show tendencies and structural relationships; it cannot claim to document what was posted recently on social media platforms. What it can do is make the patterns visual here, and the patterns here are not arbitrary.

- Slang terms that are based in approval are rewarded most by the social engagement metric
- Slang terms that are based in emphasis cluster heavily on text-heavy based platforms
- Slang terms that are based in insults travel the fastest and stick hardest in subculture spaces

They describe the social logic of sex different structures for human attention.

Language did not change when it moved online, but the platforms just gave us new ways to see it.